

as hostage situations. It's said that in California alone, almost one-fifth of all SWAT teams own one of these robots.

The base of the robot (which can be controlled remotely) looks like that of a small battle tank. It has multiple add-ons, an example being detachable robotic arms which could search and extract bombs. The robot could bring in supplies and also support negotiations through audio and video feed in hostage situations. The drive system of the robot can address indoor navigation issues pretty effectively. It also has a power system which works with the aid of commodity batteries and also an operating system which has a rather fast feedback loop.

And given how fast innovations are happening, the company has already filed for some 30 odd patents. It's not hard to envision a future in which the robots may end up becoming the norm than the exception.



Freeze!

The solar robot

A robotic system that can improve energy collection at solar farms may just be the thing that's needed in a period of widespread energy crisis. The good news is that Qbotix, a California based company has a worthy solution.

The robots from Qbotix are easy-to-install and hit the market in 2012. The current roster of clients include folks from both America and Japan. The robots are smart and autonomous, and they can work in the middle-of-nowhere on solar farms for decades notwithstanding the high temperatures and winds that are common in such places. The modus operandi involves installing the robots along a monorail track, thereby controlling around 1,200 small solar panels. The robots will rotate each panel towards the sun once every 40 minutes. Collectively, these small solar panels could power 30 homes. They also come equipped with sensors which collect data and track dust buildup on the panels which affects efficiency.